LoDA-SA: Low-Frequency Distance-Aware Sparse Attention

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***Abstract*—Sparse attention must retain useful candidates at low selection cost. We study LoDA-SA, a distance-aware two-level selector: a near–far page-to-token cascade with shared 32-coordinate low-frequency RoPE scoring, original-dimensional attention on selected tokens, and absolute budgets: protected sink and window lengths, near extent n_l, near page budget n_b with far pages K_1-n_b by subtraction, and one free-competition token pool; nonaligned protection-boundary pages join candidates outside the quotas. Ratio-coupled parameterizations instead silently reallocate far capacity: one expression links the far token budget to three knobs, and archived diagnostics exhibit all three failures, including an exact integer threshold. The absolute interface makes page capacities explicit and drops regional token quotas. An 87-cell grid on five LongBench tasks (Qwen3-8B) attributes quality to near pages and near extent, finds no token-split main effect, and averages 48.26 for quota-free selection at 32 near pages and 4096-token extent versus 47.46 for a no-partition control; archived RULER 32K runs reach 59.29. These single-run comparisons establish neither non-inferiority nor mechanisms; historical timings show slower sparse decoding, and the compact 4/128 design still requires matched quality and preparation-inclusive complete-request cost.**

***Index Terms*—sparse attention, shared representation, regional retrieval, long-context inference**

I. Introduction

Long-context decoding must retain access to useful history under a finite attention budget. Tokens at different distances compete for this budget, and global ranking alone does not reserve candidate access for a positional region. Distance therefore offers a way to organize selection, without assuming that importance decreases monotonically with distance or that near tokens are always preferable. A selector must decide which regions can supply candidates and then rank those candidates cheaply enough to justify restricting final attention.

Cascades such as AsyncTLS shortlist pages using inexpensive summaries before token refinement [4]. Mean pooling and sign-aware extrema, summaries our selector also uses, do not rank pages by their total attention weight. Following ClusterKV's token/page perspective [8], Figure 1(a) shows a single Qwen3 query where fewer missed reference pages coincide with more missed reference mass. Unequal regional allocations and realized counts preclude a controlled comparison but motivate examining how scoring and budgets shape candidate access.

Across 128 correlated observations from four sequences, the two global selectors have different regional missed-mass profiles (Fig. 1(b)). Mean missed mass, normalized by each query's total mass-ranked reference mass, is .084 near and .170 far for block averaging, versus .079 and .042 for sign-aware extrema. Extrema have lower mean misses in both regions, establishing neither regional specialization nor near-region equivalence. With a fixed 2048-token cap, the best of 23 tested near-avg/far-extrema splits has mean missed mass .135, versus .121 for global extrema. This bounded diagnostic scan establishes neither a hybrid advantage nor a task-quality benefit.

We study a two-level selector that couples a shared scoring view with absolute regional budgets. Both stages use a fixed set of 32 coordinates comprising 16 complete low-frequency RoPE pairs; the near page budget n_b and near extent n_l are absolute, far pages follow by subtraction, nonaligned protection-boundary pages join candidates outside the quotas, and L2 refines tokens in a single free-competition pool. Among the three 32-coordinate subsets in Figure 1(c), low-frequency pairs retain .84 of full-dimensional reference mid-TopK mass on average, random coordinates .51, high-frequency pairs .24; the random subset does not preserve RoPE pairs. Selected tokens use original-dimensional Q/K/V in one final attention operation. Compact coordinates narrow each scoring dot product, but ordinary L2 still scores the full history before masking; fewer shortlisted pages do not remove that work. We also formulate a prefill-informed far gate motivated by layer variation in Figure 1(d); it is disabled by default.

We contribute LoDA-SA, an absolute-budget two-level selector with shared low-frequency coordinates, a unified analysis of implicit budget coupling in ratio parameterizations, an 87-cell grid isolating near pages and near extent as the active quality axes, and separate evaluations of task quality, regional coverage and execution cost. Under the archived ratio interface, one expression in the page cap, near share and fill fraction determines the far token budget, so raising any of the three can zero it; reported Qwen3-8B RULER 32K AVG moves 0.99 points when archived near quotas shift (16,640) to (8,320), with both quotas changing together. Grid cells are single runs, and the archived sparse configuration decodes slower than dense at every measured length. Establishing a quality–latency benefit for the compact design requires matched quality and preparation-inclusive complete-request measurements.

II. Related Work

Quest supplies sign-aware page-extremum bounds, SparQ selects key coordinates from queries, and HISA prunes the attention set hierarchically [1], [2], [3]. AsyncTLS explicitly follows Quest for coarse block selection and applies Double Sparsity for fine token selection; its cascade also includes quantization, per-query normalization with GQA probability aggregation and original-KV attention [4]. Earlier Twilight uses a select-then-prune architecture [14]; LoDA-SA studies explicit distance-region page access within this hierarchical-selection paradigm, with complete low-frequency RoPE pairs shared across both stages and unified L2 competition. The relationship is algorithmic; code lineage is unverified.

The selector's own reads also matter. Token-Picker uses conservative probability estimates from partial key-bit chunks to stop further key-chunk and value transfers for pruned tokens [13]; our selector instead ranks candidates with a fixed coordinate subset under page budgets, keeping original-dimensional KV. Our selector keeps both selection stages in bf16: AsyncTLS token keys are INT4, FFD scans 2-bit keys, and official HISA pools block summaries in FP8 [4], [5], [3]; our efficiency comes from candidacy structure, regional quotas and page-level narrowing, not numeric compression. KV compression and placement methods address complementary storage and movement constraints [6], [7], [8]; a smaller scoring view retains original-KV capacity without lowering complete-request latency.

III. LoDA-SA: Distance-Aware Selection in a Shared Subspace

LoDA-SA separates three decisions: which distance regions can admit pages, how to score them with a shared compact view, and which pooled tokens enter final attention. The distance policy uses n_l for near extent and n_b for its page budget, leaving $K_1 - n_b$ far pages. The implementation prepares the shared 32-coordinate view before regional L1 selection (Fig. 2), an execution order distinct from

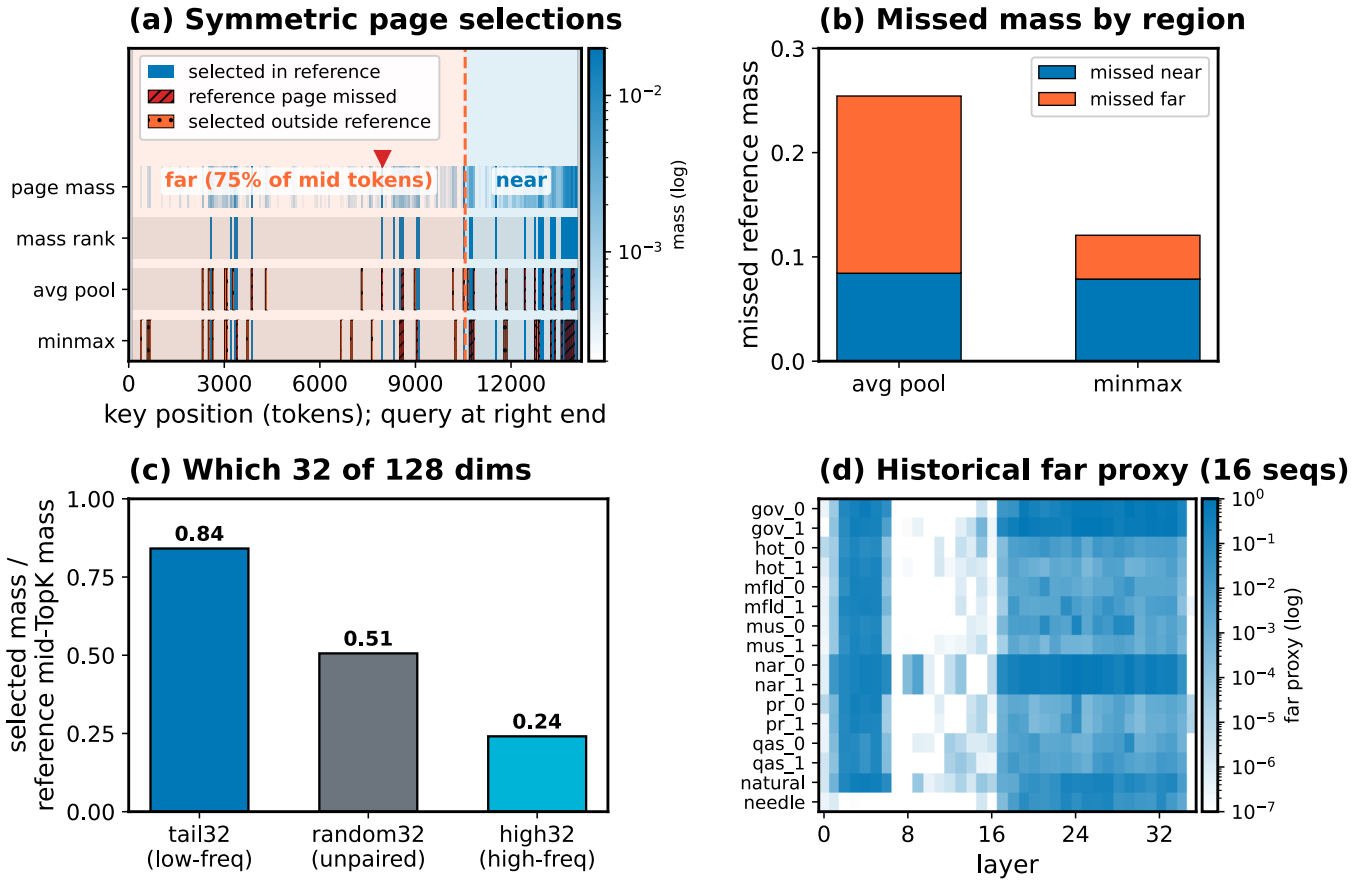


Fig. 1. Motivating diagnostics for LoDA-SA; Qwen3-8B, 128/128 prefix/recent protection in (a)–(c). (a) MuSiQue sample 1, layer 24, query 14212. The top strip shows summed attention per page, not a selection; below are stored mass-rank, avg and minmax selections, 32 pages each, using 1989/1989/2048 tokens under a 2048 cap. Avg/minmax miss 13/17 reference pages holding 59.65%/26.46% of reference-page mass. Blue: selected reference pages; red hatching: missed reference; orange dots: selected outside the reference. Mass-rank is a whole-page reference, not an optimal oracle, exact TopK or DSA. Avg and minmax share 32 coordinates and head aggregation; the reference uses full-dimensional weights. Unequal regional allocations and realized counts preclude inferring specialization or task quality from these misses. (b) Mean regional shares of missed reference mass: per-query missed mass in each region divided by total mass-ranked reference mass, averaged across 128 correlated observations from four sequences. Extrema miss less in both regions; this does not establish specialization. (c) Selected mass relative to full-dimensional reference mid-TopK mass; random32 does not preserve RoPE pairs. (d) One 16-by-36 historical single-query proxy matrix gives 24/36 layer medians below .01 and 12–32 low-proxy layers per sequence, using the last sampled query, group-logit summation before softmax and far interval $[64, t-2048)$ (S6), unlike the optional gate statistic. These are diagnostics, not task-quality or decode-safety results.

our distance-first explanation. Selection runs only during decoding, with dense prefill; gating and candidate gathering stay disabled, and archived runs do not validate current LoDA-SA.

A. Distance regions and candidate budgets

In decoding, t indexes the current token across the full sequence including prefill. Let s and w denote the protected sink and recent-window lengths, with protected set $\mathcal{P}_t = \{i : 0 \le i \le t,\ i < s \text{ or } i > t - w\}$ and unprotected middle $\mathcal{M}_t = \{0, \dots, t\} \setminus \mathcal{P}_t$; overlapping protection counts once. The requested near length is n_l tokens. The implementation uses at least one page, $L = \max(B, n_l)$, then floors the near/far cut to a page boundary: near ends at the protected window, and far is the remaining middle history.

Selected near and far pages, together with protection-boundary bypass pages, form one L2 candidate pool. There is no prescribed near/far token split: regional representation in the final set follows the scores, not a token quota. With enough positive-probability candidates, L2 cannot recover unprotected tokens from L1-rejected pages. S7 details scarce-support and masked zero-tie exceptions.

B. Shared low-frequency coordinates

Both regions and both selection stages use the same coordinate map within each layer and KV head, while each query head is scored separately. For the Qwen3-8B tail-coordinate configuration, we select post-RoPE coordinates $J = \{48, \dots, 63, 112, \dots, 127\}$ from each 128-dimensional query and key. The indices retain 16 complete low-frequency split-half RoPE pairs (Supplementary Fig. S1); this statement does not describe generic full-width, static-pair, projection or MLA configurations. With coordinate-selection matrix $E_J \in \mathbb{R}^{128\times 32}$, the scoring vectors are $z_q = E_J^\top q$ and $z_i = E_J^\top k_i$. The retained pairs' slow positional rotation motivates this selection, although it does not guarantee preservation of important tokens. The compact implementation uses width-32 scoring tensors (S7 details the historical width-128 form).

L1 aggregates selected key coordinates into page summaries for coarse ranking; L2 refines candidates with per-token scores in the same coordinate view. Original KV remain full width. Compact scoring narrows each dot product fourfold, but view preparation and maintenance add work without compressing the original KV cache (S7).

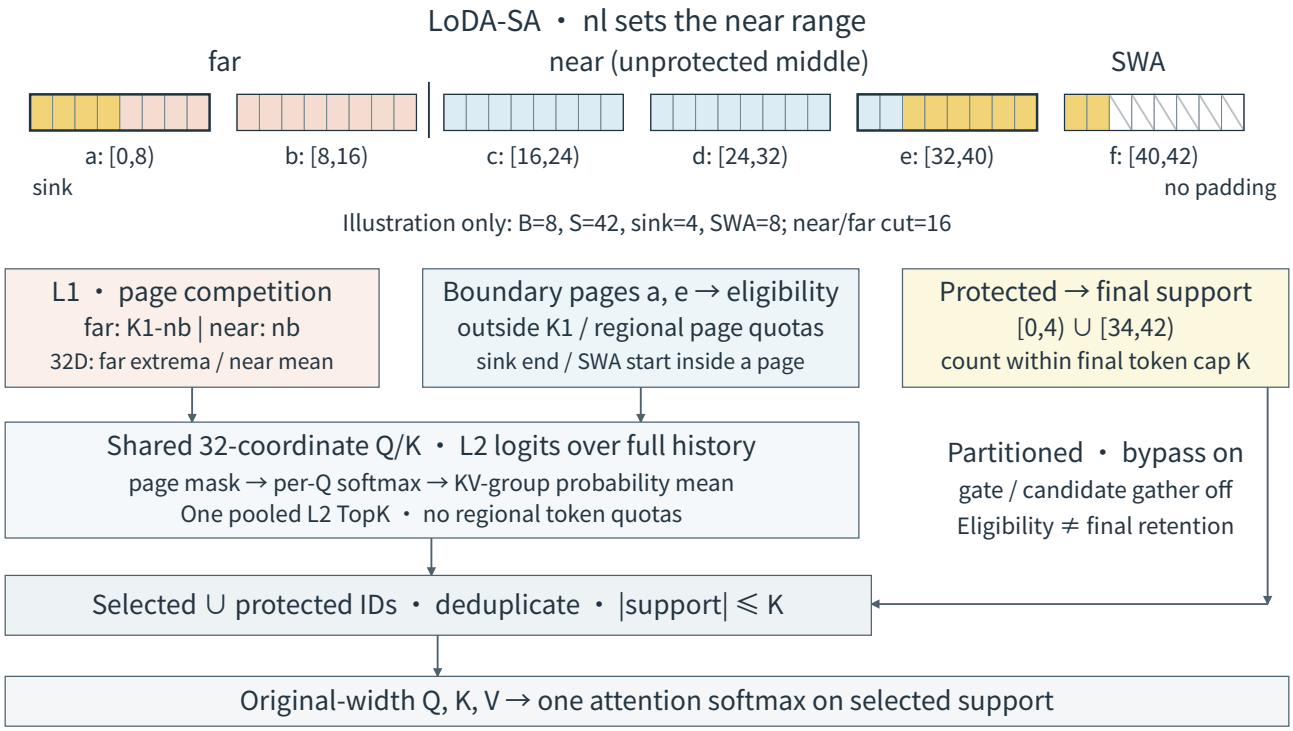


Fig. 2. LoDA-SA reference architecture: boundary bypass enabled, gating and candidate gathering disabled. A shared coordinate view feeds regional L1 page scoring and ordinary full-history L2 scoring. Nonaligned protection-boundary pages join the page mask outside L1 quotas; only protected tokens bypass final selection. Per-query softmax and KV-group probability averaging precede one pooled middle-token TopK; protected positions join deduplicated IDs within K. IDs define support over original-width K/V; physical gathering is backend-dependent. Arrays are schematic.

C. Regional page scoring and boundary eligibility

Regional page caps and one shared token budget constrain the cascade (Supplementary Fig. S2). Near pages use query–mean-key dot products to summarize page-level relevance; far pages use sign-aware extrema to bound shared-space token scores, a heuristic assignment. Summaries cover full physical pages, including protected positions (S7). In the partitioned path, a page containing a non-page-aligned sink end or recent-window start bypasses L1 ranking: it is appended outside the page quotas, and its unprotected tokens still compete in L2; only protected tokens are forced into final support. For a nonempty page b, let $m_{b,j} = \min_{i\in b} z_{i,j}$ and $M_{b,j} = \max_{i\in b} z_{i,j}$. Quest's construction [1] gives

$$U_b(z_q) = \sum_j (z_{q,j}^+ M_{b,j} + z_{q,j}^- m_{b,j}), \tag{1}$$

where $z^+ = \max(z, 0)$ and $z^- = \min(z, 0)$. Each signed coordinate contribution is bounded by its chosen extremum, so $z_q^\top z_i \le U_b(z_q)$ for every shared-space key in b. This does not bound original-dimensional logits. Extrema may come from different tokens, making the bound loose enough to misrank pages and miss important tokens; average-key scores lack this per-token bound.

D. Absolute budgets and ratio-coupling contrast

For total cap $K \ge |\mathcal{P}_t|$ and disjoint protection, the middle-token budget $K_{\text{mid}} = K - |\mathcal{P}_t|$ fills one pool: L2 applies the retained-page mask, then a single TopK over group-averaged probabilities retains up to K_{mid} tokens regardless of region. The interface exposes absolute quantities: near page budget n_b, far pages $K_1 - n_b$ by subtraction (page quotas clipped to availability), and near extent n_l. Neither region's page capacity moves without its own parameter.

Ratio-coupled interfaces hide this subtraction. The archived parameterization derives $n_b = \max(1, \text{round}(\beta K_1))$ and $n_k = \min(\lfloor \gamma n_b B \rfloor, K_{\text{mid}})$ with ties-to-even rounding, so the far token budget reduces to

$$k_f = \max(0,\ K_{\text{mid}} - \min(\gamma n_b B,\ K_{\text{mid}})). \tag{2}$$

Three knobs, K_1, β and γ, therefore reallocate far capacity through one expression, while far pages remain admitted at $k_f = 0$: page eligibility and token capacity are separate constraints. Archived diagnostics exhibit all three reallocations, including an exact integer threshold at which raising K_1 zeroes far tokens (Q2, S6). The absolute interface is immune by construction: the token pool is stated, not derived, and no knob combination can zero a region's access.

The compact configuration ($K = 1024$, $s = 4$, $w = 128$, $n_b = 32$, $n_l = 4096$) leaves 892 middle slots per KV head, with L1 admitting 32 near and 96 far pages (Supplementary Fig. S2); the partial prefix page can reselect up to four protected tokens, so retained coverage is nominal.

E. GQA selection and original-dimensional attention

GQA assigns four of Qwen3's 32 query heads to each of its eight KV heads. L1 averages their page scores before regional TopK. Ordinary L2 computes each query's full-history logits, applies the shared page mask, then softmax. Group-averaged probabilities determine one TopK across the pooled middle tokens. L2 uses scale $1/\sqrt{128}$ before softmax even with 32 scoring coordinates. Because softmax precedes group averaging, this rule generally differs from applying softmax to group-averaged logits.

TABLE I
Compact design parameters and execution policy. Explicit n_l, n_b values remain configuration parameters, not verified measurements here. K includes unique protected tokens.

Parameter	Setting
Final token cap K	1024
Page size; L1 page cap K_1	64; 128
Near page budget n_b (far)	32 (96)
Near extent n_l	4096 tokens, page-aligned
L2 token selection	single pool, free competition
L1/L2 active coordinates	32/32
Prefix / recent protection	4/128
Prefill; decode layers	dense; all sparse

For KV group h, let $\mathcal{S}_{t,h}$ be the deduplicated union of protected positions and pooled winners, with $|\mathcal{S}_{t,h}| \le K$. Each query g uses this support for its own full-dimensional attention ($d = 128$):

$$o_{h,g} = \sum_{i \in \mathcal{S}_{t,h}} \frac{e^{q_{h,g}^\top k_{i,h}/\sqrt{d}}}{\sum_{j \in \mathcal{S}_{t,h}} e^{q_{h,g}^\top k_{j,h}/\sqrt{d}}} v_{i,h}. \tag{3}$$

Each query applies one softmax over the merged indices, avoiding the addition of separately normalized regional outputs [9]. Full-dimensional retained logits still use a restricted denominator, which can change the output. Physical KV gathering depends on backend and length; short sequences can use a dense masked path.

F. Scope of optional far gating

The current n_l/n_b design keeps far gating disabled. A historical extension calibrates far mass from final prefill queries after per-head causal softmax, then freezes a layer decision at sparse decoding; its numeric-token-quota refill branch is not the current unified L2 rule (S5). In the unified branch, removing far-page competition does not remove all final far tokens: a sink-boundary page may still enter the pooled competition, so we claim no complete far skipping and transfer no historical gate results. Calibration thresholds do not bound decode error; quality and complete-request cost require separate evaluation.

IV. Experimental Setting

We evaluate three aspects separately: task quality (Q1), regional candidate coverage (Q2) and execution cost (Q3). Table I defines the compact Qwen3-8B design: dense prefill, sparse decoding and a 1024-token cap including four prefix and 128 recent tokens (the 4/128-protection design). We selected n_b and n_l from an 87-cell LongBench grid (Q2), whose token-split axis shows no main effect; L2 fills K_{mid} by free competition, the archived γ-off mode. Archived runs use ratios (α, β, γ) mapping to the same geometry via the §III formulas with page-aligned $n_l = \lfloor \alpha |\mathcal{M}_t| \rfloor$; $(8, 320)$ equals the archived $(.25, .0625, .625)$ cell, whose quality runs applied 16-level quantize–dequantize L2 token keys outside the mainline and, for the shared-subspace arm, 128/128 protection with 32 active coordinates in zero-filled width-128 L2 keys (S7). The labels "full-dimensional page/token scoring" denote reported variants without complete execution configurations, not controlled ablations.

Workloads and comparisons. Reported quality covers five-task LongBench [10] and 11-task RULER [11] (Qwen3-8B: 32K/64K, historical 128K), plus ported Quest/AsyncTLS/JSSA baselines. FullKV is dense and uncapped (RULER/decode timing). Method comparisons must disclose native prefill/decode paths; policy-matched adaptations need separate reporting. Budget matching aligns final unique-token caps K including protection; realized counts and head sharing affect KV traffic, and equal K alone establishes neither (S7).

Metrics. Primary quality is task-score AVG over each fixed benchmark/length set; per-task gains and losses explain AVG without zero-loss requirements. Policy-matched controls require matched models, samples, lengths, scorers, phase policies and aligned sparse-token budgets; incomplete sets lack full-set AVG. Regional miss shares divide missed reference mass by page region (Fig. 1(b)); panel (c) normalizes by full-dimensional mid-TopK mass. Neither selector time (synthetic single-layer) nor synchronized TPOT (model-level post-first-output intervals) measures preparation-inclusive complete-request latency, so unpaired studies define no quality–latency frontier; AVG differences are descriptive, not non-inferiority evidence.

V. Evaluation and Discussion

A. Q1: Does reduced scoring width preserve task quality?

On HotpotQA, Qasper, MuSiQue, GovReport and RepoBench-P [10], five-task means fall within a 0.33-point spread: shared-subspace 47.588, the nominal page variant 47.910 and the token variant 47.666 (Supplementary Fig. S4). These differences describe recorded configurations, not evidence that reduced width preserves quality: the variants are not verified single-factor interventions. All three arms are sparse; dense FullKV is a different reference.

B. Q2: How do regional budgets constrain candidate access?

Grid-isolated axes. An 87-cell absolute-quota grid (Qwen3-8B, five LongBench tasks, one run per cell) sweeps near pages, near extent and the token quota. A no-partition control averages 47.46; free competition at $(n_b, n_l) = (32, 4096)$ averages 48.26, the best quota-free cell 48.30. Near-page marginal means rise monotonically from 46.37 to 48.21 and flatten at 64, and best cells cluster near $n_b B \approx n_l/2$, matching near-region mass concentration (top-half pages hold a median .93). The token quota shows no main effect: it beats free competition by a mean of .04 across 69 cells (42/69 positive), so the design drops the split; the best quota cell exceeds the best quota-free cell by .37, and top-3 paired bootstrap intervals contain zero (S6).

Archived RULER 32K arms move 58.30→59.29 as near quotas shift $(16, 640) \to (8, 320)$ (archived $\beta = .125 \to .0625$), with far pages rising 112→120 and the far token budget 252→572 jointly; the near-page-4 arms score 58.07 ($K_1 = 128$, far tokens 732) and 58.96 ($K_1 = 256$, near quotas $(8, 320)$ with far pages 248), both below 59.29, the $K_1 = 256$ arm differing by CWE $+3.9$ and FWE -9.67. Records match; predictions are unreplayed.

Implicit coupling failures. Archived diagnostics exhibit all three reallocations of Eq. (2). Integer enumeration of the archived formulas locates the first far-zero page cap at $K_1 = 156$ for $K = 1024$ ($B = 64$, $\beta = .125$, $\gamma = .625$, 128/128 protection); far budget 8 remains at $K_1 = 155$, so capacity appears to grow while far tokens vanish. Archived task scans collapse HotpotQA from 53.6–57.3 to 37.7 exactly on zero-far-budget arms, graded by far fraction (16.4 points at .875, about 1 at .125). At the archived grid cell $(\alpha, \beta) = (.25, .125)$, free competition ties the best γ within .001 in retained-mass diagnostics (.852 versus .8515), while $\gamma = 0$ reads as far-free but zeroes the near token quota, dropping retained mass to .827. The historical 128K RULER arm computed $k_f = 0$ under its reported budgets (S6). These archived diagnostics unify the three anomalies but are not new controlled experiments.

Reported 32K AVG gap to dense FullKV is -0.09 across machines; at 64K, AVGs are 48.85/48.05 for near quotas (8,320)/(16,640) versus 48.54. Sparse arms share a machine and scorer hashes but differ in prediction scripts; the dense anchor differs in scorer and identity, and missing paired intervals preclude causal conclusions (S8).

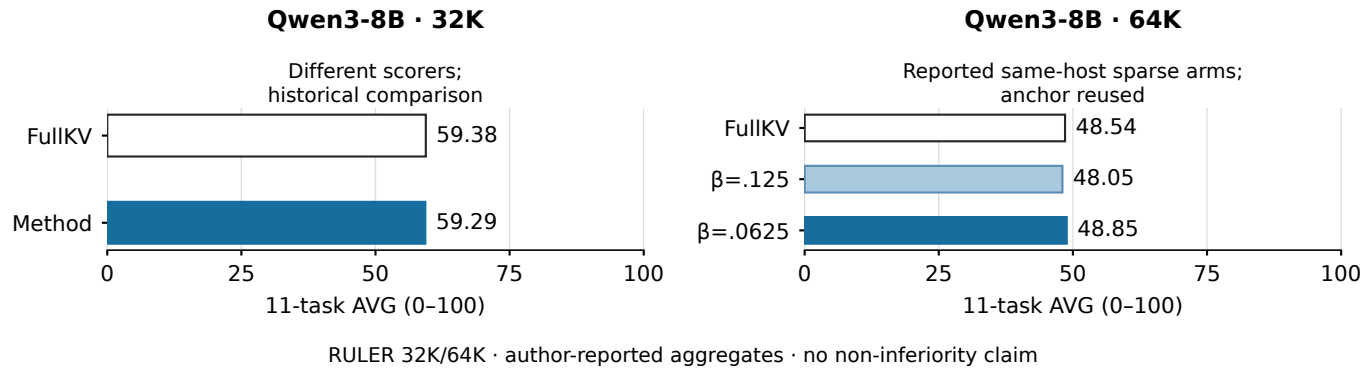


Fig. 3. Author-reported RULER 32K/64K AVG on Qwen3-8B: 11 tasks, 100 examples/task/arm. FullKV is dense; archived sparse arms report $K = 1024$, protection 4/128 under ratio-derived token quotas, predating the selected free-competition configuration. At 32K, near quotas (8,320) ($\beta = .0625$); at 64K, (8,320) and (16,640) are both shown. The 32K comparison spans machines (scorers differ, input identity partial); the 64K sparse arms are reported on one machine, the FullKV anchor a separate run. Gate status and scoring dimensions are unverified. These descriptive scores establish neither non-inferiority nor matched quality–cost benefit (S8).

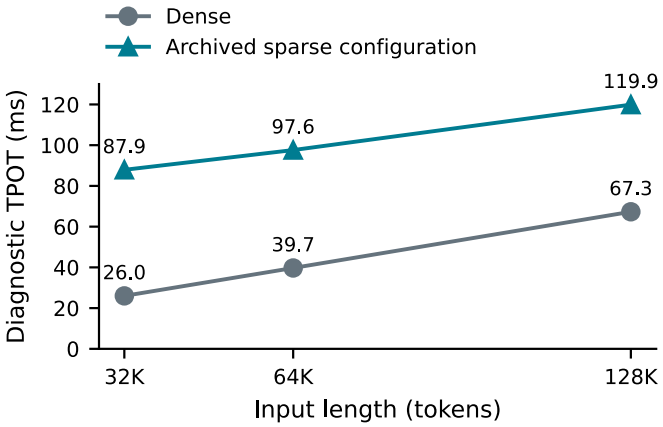


Fig. 4. Author-reported model-level decode TPOT for an archived sparse configuration and dense FullKV, Qwen3-8B with dynamic cache. Fixed 128-token output gives 127 after-first intervals, including synchronization and argmax. The archived $(.125, .375, .625)$ setting differs from the current design; medians measure no complete-request E2E and establish no matched quality–cost comparison (S6).

Ported baselines. Author-reported AVGs (nominal 512): 56.00 (ours) versus 48.33 (AsyncTLS), a 7.67-point gap; budgets, protection and execution phases are unverified. At $K = 1024$, 59.29 compares with JSSA's 58.7, Quest's 42.85 and FASA's 18.64; $K = 384$ scores 15.00. S8 gives provenance, CWE's 43.4-point loss and absent paired intervals.

At 128K, the (8,320)/(16,640) arms score 45.73/46.02 on one machine; 45.73 is 98.49% of the separate-run dense anchor 46.43. Historical RULER 128K yields 23.98 under budgets implying $k_f = 0$, execution unverified, the 22.45-point loss unexplained (S6). Five-task LongBench means are 26.09 (protection-only, 256 tokens) versus 47.91 (reused sparse, 1024); retrieval and budget both change.

C. Q3: Does compact scoring reduce execution cost?

Model-level decoding. Sparse TPOT medians are 87.9, 97.6 and 119.9 ms at 32K, 64K and 128K versus dense 26.0, 39.7 and 67.3 ms: the reported configuration is slower at every measured length (Fig. 4), with no decode-time benefit. Timings include synchronization and argmax, use a non-compact configuration, and cannot locate causes or predict the compact implementation (S6).

Local selector cost. A separate two-round synthetic experiment (single layer, batch one, one query, 64K QKV) reports steady-state summaries of 1.3502, 1.3598 and 1.4634 ms (page, shared-subspace, token variants). Missing raw sequences and an unresolved sampling discrepancy prevent assessment (S6); they identify no bottleneck and lack quality pairing.

D. Optional gate: prefill is not a decode guarantee

Low prefill attention does not establish safe decode-time skipping. An archived input–layer record pairs a prefill far-attention proxy below .05 with a decode-tail mean of .1678 over five queries: a proxy shift, not measured quality loss. Gate thresholds .05 and .10 yield five-task AVGs of 47.876 and 47.692 against the reused 47.910 reference (three tasks decline per arm; HotpotQA 1.05 and 1.26). Neither these changes nor zero-containing bootstrap intervals establish non-inferiority; missing configurations, paired predictions and matched costs leave gated quality and net savings unverified (S6).

Design implications and limitations. Two constraints recur: reduced scoring width narrows each dot product while ordinary L2 still scores full history, and page-level eligibility does not guarantee final selection, which the single pool decides by group-averaged probability. A useful operating point cuts preparation-inclusive complete-request latency at matched quality. Matched measurements for the compact design remain missing; historical gate summaries lack complete configuration identity.

VI. Conclusion

We studied LoDA-SA: shared low-frequency page/token scoring, absolute page budgets, one free-competition token pool, and original-dimensional attention on selected tokens, separating scoring width from work, eligibility from final selection, and explicit from ratio-derived budgets. An 87-cell grid attributes quality to near pages and near extent with no token-split main effect: quota-free selection averages 48.26 versus 47.46 control, and archived runs reach 59.29 at RULER 32K (98.49% of a dense anchor at 128K); single-run results leave the 128K loss and slower sparse decoding as limitations requiring matched quality and complete-request cost.

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